

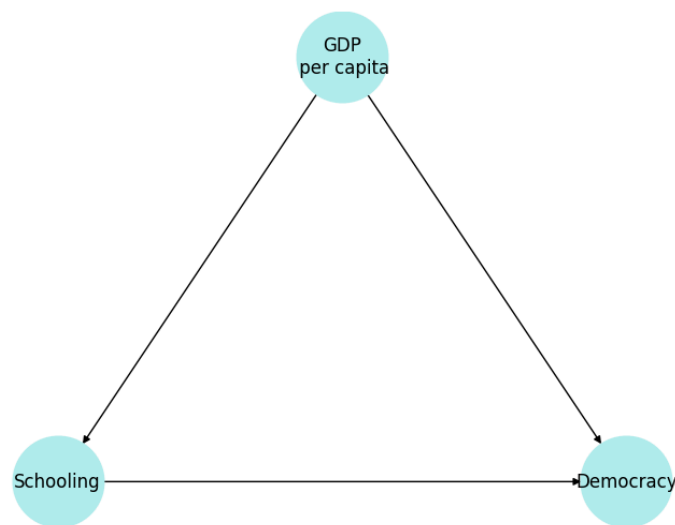
Does a higher level of education lead to a more democratic society?

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1. Introduction

Political philosophy can be defined as the philosophical reflection on how best to arrange our collective life (Miller, 1998), with a core focus on concepts such as democracy. Longer periods of schooling, otherwise known as higher levels of education, have been considered essential to democracy, at least since the writings of John Dewey (1916). We might thus expect that increased years of schooling result in more democratic societies, regardless of economic wealth, and consider GDP per capita as a confounding variable.



Could schooling have a positive effect on democracy?

- **Prediction 1:** Higher years of schooling lead to a higher democracy score.
- **Prediction 2:** Higher GDP per capita is associated with a higher democracy score.

2. Data

The dataset used is a combination of three datasets from [Our World in Data](#) (accessed on 18.01.2026). The dataset contains information about several countries, including their GDP per capita, average years of schooling and democracy score. The data correspond to the year 2020 ($N = 136$, see **Figure 1**).

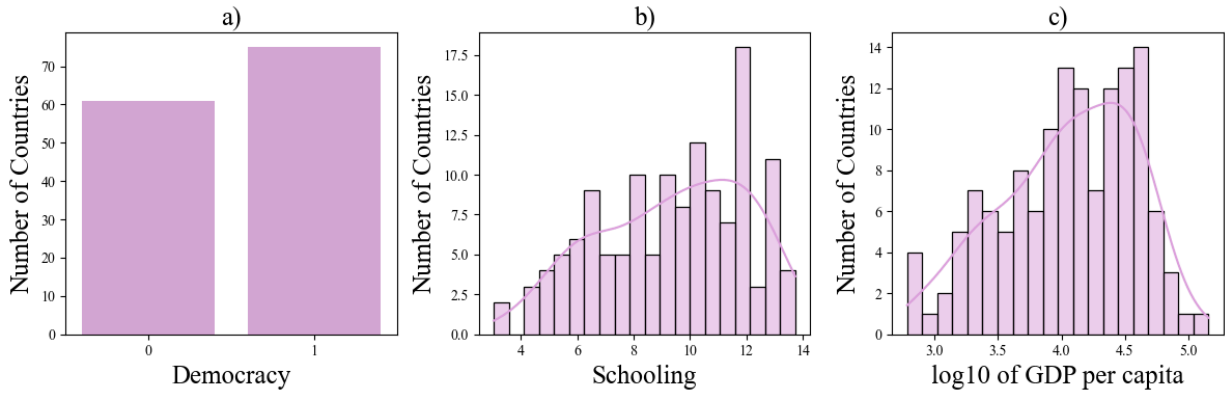


Figure 1 - Monovariate descriptions of the dataset: (a) Democracy, (b) Schooling, (c) log10 of GDP per capita of countries.

3. Methods

In order to test the two predictions, we performed a multivariate logistic regression to analyze the effect of schooling on democracy (1), while controlling for the confounding variable, GDP per capita (2) using the equation:

$$P(Democracy_i = 1 | X_i) = sig(\beta_0 + \beta_1 GDPpc_i + \beta_2 Schooling_i)$$

4. Results

The multivariate logistic regression results show that schooling has a significant positive effect on democracy ($\beta = 0.406$, $p = 0.002$, see **Figure 2**). Meanwhile, when controlling for schooling, the effect of GDPpc becomes insignificant ($p = 0.881$, see **Figure 2**). This suggests that economic wealth alone does not guarantee democracy; rather, it is the education level of the population that is the decisive factor.

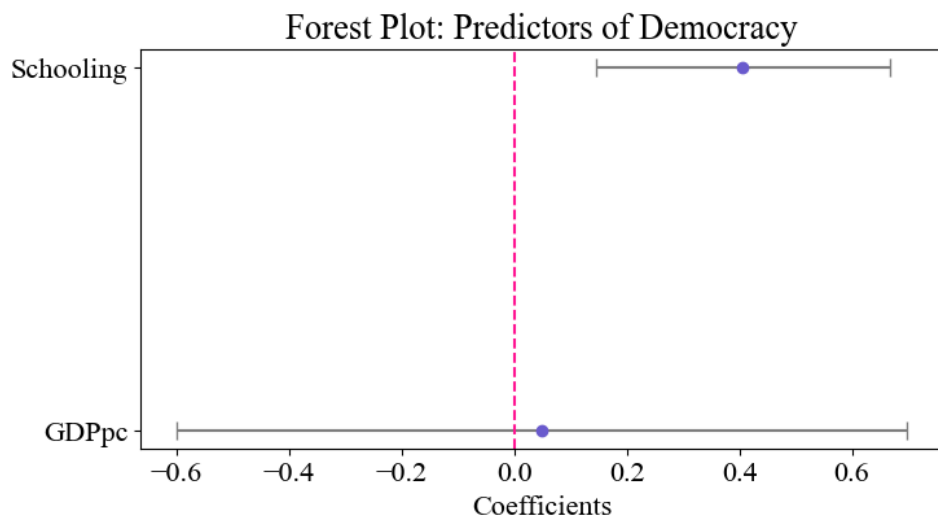


Figure 2 - Forest Plot of the Predictors of Democracy

5. Conclusion

Our results indicate that countries with higher average years of schooling tend to have a higher democracy score, regardless of the GDP per capita. These findings suggest that education is essential to the well-being of countries.

It should be noted that, while the GDP per capita was controlled as a confounding variable, the democracy score may correlate with other unobserved factors that influence both results.

6. References

Miller, D. (1998). Political philosophy. In *The Routledge Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Taylor and Francis. <https://www.rep.routledge.com/articles/overview/political-philosophy/v-1>

Dewey, J. (1916). *Democracy and education : an introduction to the philosophy of education*. New York:FreePress.<https://dn710102.ca.archive.org/0/items/democracyandeduc00deweuoft/democracyandeduc00deweuoft.pdf>